
CONTEMPLATIVE RECOVERY: The Artwork of James Turrell

Author(s): Jeffrey L. Kosky

Source: *CrossCurrents*, MARCH 2013, Vol. 63, No. 1, AESTHETIC THEOLOGY (MARCH 2013), pp. 44-61

Published by: University of North Carolina Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24462235>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



University of North Carolina Press is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *CrossCurrents*

JSTOR

CONTEMPLATIVE RECOVERY

The Artwork of James Turrell¹

Jeffrey L. Kosky

Light is not so much something that reveals as it is itself the revelation.²

One way to understand modernity is as the age in which contemplation is repressed, marginalized, or otherwise forgotten. An important emblem of this transformation is *light*. As light becomes less and less something we desire to see and more and more something we use in order to see, the world becomes not a radiant appearance whose beauty is to be admired but an object to examine and grasp.

An acknowledged master and pioneer of the use of light in modern art, James Turrell makes work that defies the modern obsession with a certain kind of light: the direct or focused light that illuminates an otherwise darkened space so that we can see objects clearly and distinctly. Absorbed in Turrell's work, we give ourselves over to a vision of the light itself. Offering neither object to grasp nor image to see, Turrell's art separates what modern forms of lighting connect—seeing from controlling, touching from mastering—and introduces us into a domain where our gaze makes the transition to wonder and admiration.

In Turrell's work, then, aesthetic vision can be understood as the heir to contemplation. This makes his art a useful site for recovering something operative in contemplative traditions but repressed from mainstream interpretations of modernity—the leisure and freedom of human being and its correlative, the wonder and beauty of the world. Theologians and philosophers, as well as literary or art critics, and cultural commentators in general, who are concerned about the increasingly

rare opportunity for cultivating these habits in human beings and for approaching the world that opens to them might do well then to attend carefully to the work of this great contemporary artist.

Delumination of the world and the struggle for illumination

A familiar old story connects modernity with the dream of enlightenment. But this seemingly simple story is in fact more subtle, as the modern dream of enlightenment is in fact a wish for a certain kind of light—a light that clarifies and, thanks to its clarity, lets us see solid and stable objects. Solid and stable objects require well-defined limits and edges; they appear in distinct places defined by sharp borders that contain the objects held in place there. This distinctness is possible only in a clearly lit space. Along these lines, the French polymath Michel Serres will point to the “association of the distinct with the clear, the language of light with the language of borders,”³ for the edges and borders that define distinct objects appear sharply only in a light that is clear.

This enlightenment is perhaps nowhere more obvious than when René Descartes, widely acknowledged as a founding father of modernity, takes the standard of evidence to be the clear and distinct. That is to say, Descartes resolves to accept as true only what appears clearly and distinctly to his gaze. Clarity and distinctness, joined in the fashion Serres described, become the defining characteristics of an evidence that appears beyond the shadow of doubt: when things appear with such an evidence, any suspicion that what appears might be a false or misleading appearance is dispelled. Defining what appears in truth as any and all objects that come to light in such a clear light, Descartes thereby establishes reality (that is, appearing in truth) on the foundation of certainty. What lacks certainty is either not real or not yet established in truth. Descartes thus believes he is closest to reality, dwells most firmly in the truth, when he sees with certainty.

Not only does the modern dream of enlightenment dream of a particular kind or function of light, it also dreams that this light is under human control. According to a provocative suggestion made by Hans Blumenberg, this dream accounts for the importance in modernity of the idea of method: “In the idea of ‘method’, which originates with Bacon and Descartes, the ‘light’ is thought of as being at man’s disposal. Phenomena no longer stand in the light; rather they are *subjected to the*

lights of an examination."⁴ An examination directed by the human mind shines the light in which the truth is produced; what does not stand as the outcome of such an effort to shine a light on matters does not appear in truth and will not count as real. In the context of this examination, method becomes increasingly important as only procedures that follow the proper method are guaranteed to shine a clarifying light.

That shining the light of truth should come under the methodical administration and technical control of the human implies that the world has suffered what Blumenberg calls "de-lumination."⁵ No longer appearing in the light of its own, natural splendor, the world must be illuminated from the outside, as it were, if it is to appear in truth. From the perspective of the modern enlightenment, only the deluded ancients trusted in the natural luminosity of things and the world. As for the ignorant medievals, the modern self-justification goes, though they did not believe in a natural illumination, they did believe that the light in which we might see truly would be given to us graciously from above or beyond by a divine power; human beings need not work or do works to shine the light in which reality appears in truth, even if they might, according to some, still need to make some effort on themselves in order to receive or open this light of illumination. To the nascent modern mind, according to Blumenberg, both the ancient and the modern positions evidence a naïve trust in what seems to show itself as truth. In enlightened modernity, by contrast, trust is replaced by effort: the truth is brought out of its hiding in the darkness of the world only by human activities or technical procedures that shine a light on it. In Blumenberg's words, "the truth does not reveal itself; it must be *revealed*."⁶

In this context, we can approach the modern repression of contemplation and with it, the loss of an important determination of human being and the world. As humans assume control of the light that brings the world to light, there is a corresponding change in the nature and function of theory. More specifically, theory as contemplation yields to theory as knowledge in the service of mastery. Contemplative vision is lost, forgotten, or rendered obsolete as vision and insight are more and more put to the task of mastering and altering the world.

In the ancient world of the pre-Socratics as described by Blumenberg, light was natural, the nature of beings even. As naturally, self-illuminating, or radiant, things did not come to light in an illumination made by a light

prior to or outside them, but shined of themselves, generously as it were. Man then encounters beings by rendering himself (surrendering) to the light by which things offer and present themselves. This calm surrender to the light, Blumenberg argues, is the meaning of knowledge or *theoria*, here taken as contemplation. "Cognition in its highest form arises in the inactive, calm, contemplation of *theoria*.... The drama of truth is not a cosmic *agon* between light and darkness but rather only a process of man's withdrawing himself or handing himself over"⁷ (p. 32). Mankind need not struggle to illuminate things for things to appear in truth; he need only release himself from the troubles of the world and contemplate this unveiling of beings in a shining that happens insistently.

What Blumenberg describes as the ancient calm of contemplative repose looking on in leisure amidst light shining naturally is disturbed in the modern world; the patient waiting for light graciously given becomes anxious; as human beings assume the position of making and shining light on what, without this light, remains hidden in the darkness. With the rise of modern society and modern culture, theory is translated from the carefree domain of contemplation to the careful domain of knowing in view of shedding a light on things that are hidden in the dark. In Blumenberg's words, "theory will no longer relate to the resting point of a blissful onlooker but rather to the workplace of human exertion."⁸ Here, in this workplace, one does not look into things in a carefree way in order to enjoy the liberty of vision in the free and clear (*theoria* as contemplation); rather one looks at them carefully, full of concern, in order to shine on them the light of an examination that brings them out of the threatening darkness into true knowledge (theory as methodical examination). Theory is thus detached from the place of happiness occupied by a leisurely contemplator (what Blumenberg calls "bliss") and becomes instead a mode of effort and concern for oneself aiming at security. Contemplation having been forgotten by nascent modernity, the human vision of the world (theory) is now tied to "self-assertion through the mastery and alteration of reality."⁹ Human being grows more and more secure as the world comes to light in terms of our illuminating examination. We are not called on to be patient attenders to what appears shiningly before us, but to be active and assertive workers, shapers of the appearance of things.

But, mastery and self-assertion bring their own burdens, and it remains unclear to many of us whether assuming the position of master and shaper of reality is indeed a promotion when it affords control rather than enjoyment, when it demands assertive projection of oneself rather than offering a vision that is free. Our vision is not free, after all, when it costs so much time and effort. We moderns are uncomfortable venturing into the free and clear where we might release ourselves to a vision of what there is to see, wanting instead to stay in the more secure realm where we see something, some object we ourselves have worked so hard to shape. Security achieved quiets the anxious concern of living in a deluminated world; it brings us to live the seemingly calm or carefree life, but unlike “the resting point of a blissful onlooker” as Blumenberg calls it, the calm of this secure life rests on the ground of effort and struggle, on the anxious self-concern and worry that lies quietly under it—so quietly that it is often forgotten in security achieved.

Theologians and philosophers—and more generally any cultural critic—concerned about keeping our free time and what we do with it might do well, then, to look for another light than that of the modern enlightenment. If they were to find such a light, they might save the rich beauty of the world from its reduction to clear and distinct objectivity—offering us something to enjoy, not master, and bidding us rise, at least for a moment, to the place of leisurely contemplators, not anxious workers.

We might look to the artist James Turrell for such a light.

Seeing the light: light as revelation

The lightboxes made by James Turrell offer training in seeing a light marginalized and forgotten by the modern enlightenment, and in doing so, they offer a contemplative recovery to modernity, bringing contemplation out of oblivion as a mode of revealing reality, perhaps healing some of the pain from what has been cut off of in modernity.

“Light is not so much something that reveals as it is itself the revelation,” Turrell claims. Taking a step back from the modern subject’s occupation with objects its self-assertive examination has illuminated clearly and distinctly, Turrell’s artwork reverses the neglect of the light and corresponding fascination with objects seen in the light. His work gives us to see a light that does not reveal objects but is itself a revelation of light. We see the light, but no object in it. “There is no object in my

work,” Turrell claims. “There never was. There is no image within it.” And yet, we see something—though we cannot grasp it clearly and distinctly. Neither hand nor eye prove capable of grasping ultimately or definitively what is seen when light itself is the revelation. Precisely because Turrell’s art works with a light that does not illuminate a dark space, these artworks lead into a non-objective world I do not inhabit by mastery. Security is lacking here, even if its seeming opposite, anxious concern, is, too. Such a vision of the world points toward a recovery of the contemplative.

A brief account of the artwork is called for. I rely on my own experience as well as descriptions offered by the art historian Georges Didi-Huberman.¹⁰ I will start with *Catso Red* (1967), 1994 and *Danae* 1983, permanent installations at the Mattress Factory in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania.

The rooms glow dimly. What light there is comes from a colored wall (*Danae*) or a colored box (*Catso Red*)—glowing, shining radiantly. A glowing rectangle. A shining cube. There they are before me. What could be more evident, seen more distinctly, and presented with more certainty than a cube and a rectangle, perfect geometrical shapes? Almost the definition of an object, yet, unbelievably, these objects are shining, themselves illuminating, or emitting light.

What are they made of? Where are they located? What keeps them hovering in the air, in seeming defiance of weight and gravity? How did they come to appear as and where they do? In order to shine a light on matters and ascertain what this is, I try moving around to gain a better perspective from which to examine it or to see other aspects of the unknown thing, making for a more thorough examination in view of constituting it more certainly. But my efforts to examine this radiant thing add nothing to it; no more information is gained when I see it from different angles or another perspective. None is better than the other—in the presence of this shining light, there is, in fact, no better place to be, no place to which I should direct myself in an effort to see it more completely. There is, it seems, nothing more for me to do than just look. Shining a better light on it or seeing it in a more focused light is equally unhelpful, for it hides nothing in the dark, covers nothing in shadows, and keeps nothing in reserve. There is nothing I can do to constitute an adequate image of the thing, and yet it appears there all the more plainly. Issuing no challenge to my perception to bring it forth and

demanding no effort of my mind to comprehend it, the thing nevertheless still presents itself.

A revelation of light, not something revealed in the light.

Since my eyes cannot grasp what they see, I try my hands. Perhaps they can grasp this shining thing even if my eyes cannot give enough to let my mind do so. But when I reach out and try to grasp this thing as if it were an object I could secure, I find nothing: there is no distinct edge or border—nothing solid, and yet there is a vision. As Didi-Huberman puts it, “Your hand will search without ever finding anything.”¹¹ These things offer no objective anchor to which I might secure myself by positioning myself in relation to them. It is difficult if not impossible even to say how far away I am from something whose edge cannot be ascertained. Where then am I, if I cannot secure myself in relation to any object in the world?

Consider in this regard *Danae*. Standing before it in this empty room that could be anywhere but is here, one’s vision oscillates, seeing wall then doorway, façade then window, illuminated surface then radiant opening. Placed before me or standing opposite me is an opening—an opening that, however, presents an opposition or a surface. This surface, by presenting a hole or opening, bids me pass through it, yet I cannot see a way out of the volume I am bid pass through. It becomes something I look into, deeply and without end, rather than something I look at; space appears to grow deeper and deeper, as if saturated with light from an inexhaustible depth it cannot contain. My vision never seems to come to rest on it, leaving me finally inadequate to its depths. Self-assertion comes up short in the face of depths which I cannot measure or measure up to.

Didi-Huberman explains how Turrell makes these containers for the uncontainable where the invisible saturates visibility, what he calls “frames for the unlimited..., for the play of the open and the frame, ... tiny cathedrals where man finds himself walking in color.” A bevel, carefully cut to a sharp angle on the wall, frames the light and makes it stand out distinctly by defining edges that secure a place where an object appears opposite you. But this distinct cutout, this object forming before your eyes, is presented against a background, the back wall of the room, lit the same color. “In this way, the color is cut-out and distinct in front (as wall section) and infinite in back (as deprived of visible limit).

The opening poses an obstacle, and the wall (in back) presents to the eye only an unlimited opening... The opening makes for a limit; the closure abolishes it.”¹² The opening lets light find a fixed shape as a visible object to see while the closure in back ensures that light withdraws into invisibility. Before you is an object, distinct and presenting itself, yet you can see through this object the unlimited light it limits and in limiting so presents a place for it to rise into visibility.

The non-object that radiates here is not an illusion, Turrell insists, rejecting any suggestion that his work be conceived as *trompe l'oeil*. An illusion vanishes or is at least explained when you adopt the right place from which to see it and examine it with great care and effort. In Turrell's viewing chambers, there is no right place where you can stand to make the illusion vanish, no privileged object whose appearance you constitute or discover by examining it in the proper light or from a series of successive angles all the while keeping the object in mind.

There is nothing to see but what you see. No need to worry, even if you don't feel secure.

But not everybody in our enlightened modernity finds this so reassuring; indeed few can conjugate insecurity into absence of worry. The unchanging invariance and quiet simplicity of Turrell's lightboxes prove unsatisfying, indeed maddening, to many modern visitors. They find themselves anxious and unsettled in them. When “light is no longer this abstract quality that renders objects visible, [but] is itself the object... of vision,” one's gaze loses the power it had to master and control the field of vision. There have been some lawsuits, as disoriented visitors in a frenzy to find their way or locate something solid and stable have bumped into walls, lost their footing, or stumbled and fallen mistakenly through exit doors. Others leave feeling cheated, deprived of the chance to see something, or wondering if they saw what they were supposed to see. What Didi-Hubermann calls “a light clarifying nothing, presenting itself as visual substance” does not make for a satisfying or adequate object of the gaze.¹³ Visitors unable to accept a thing that presents itself without their effort being responsible for bringing it to light will not believe it truly comes to light; they grow anxious and seek security from such concern.

Consider in this regard *Pleiades*, also a permanent installation at the Mattress Factory. A dark room, so dark that whether I close or open my eyes, I see nothing. But as I wait patiently, suspend my efforts to see

more clearly, and remain vigilant while sitting in the quiet dark, I begin to see bright flashes of light. At first, these are only afterimages produced by my retina continuing to fire in lingering response to the light of the world from which I have withdrawn. Pressure exerted on the nerves in my eyes as blood pulses through my veins or as my body moves with the breath it breathes also produces some of these flashes. They are the flashing of the senses that normally work to operate the appearance of what is now operating in the absence of anything to gaze at. With the reality of the world suspended, I see myself, my own senses sensing, in the absence of anything external to see.

If I wait still longer in this dark night, this deserted place, not only the physical world but also the activity inside me switches off or falls quiet and the retinal afterimages fade away. Then, a faint light rises in the darkness. This light could not be seen so long as the illuminated world left its residue in me in the form of afterimages, and it could not be seen behind the effects produced by my own mental and bodily activity. But, now, in my inactive calm and detached quiet, a simple light dawns—the barest minimum of photons detectable by the human eye, the dimmest revelation of a minimal light, so simple and almost nothing that it would dissolve if made to appear in a space illuminated by a light other than it. Shining the light of an examination on this light would make the very thing examined vanish behind the object constituted.

I can hardly say what it is I see. Even after I leave, I remain uncertain. Did I see what there is to see there? What did others see? I am almost embarrassed to speak about it for fear of having seen wrong or not having seen what I was supposed to see. I struggle to say to others what I saw, and even when my friend says, “Yes, I saw it, too,” I remain unsure. Did I communicate what I intended? Is what I intended to say in any way close to the thing that appeared to me? Did my friend really share my vision, or is he only trying to make me feel some sense of community in a mere verbal agreement with me? The unsettling experience of the dark viewing chamber is to be delivered over to the free and open where you are not supposed to see anything but what you see. It is difficult to be simple, to simply see what vision proposes, and it is difficult to enjoy such freedom where visions are had as if for free. It can be ever so isolating to be in a situation where you are supposed to see just what you see:

the rise to objectivity is blocked, and with it the rise to a view that would be common to all, not plagued by subjectivity.

This experience can be so totally disarming that many critics neglect Turrell's work or dismiss it. It is often said about his spaces that there is nothing there to see, no object to occupy the gaze, no work to represent in learned examination—only an experience to be had and the theatrical in which to be immersed. For many, this makes a visit to the viewing chambers a useless expenditure of time and money wasted in pursuit of nothing real, just a glimmer of light. Rather than see revelations of light, these critics want to stick with objects seen in the light where they lend themselves to the objective accounts of historians, critics, and journalists who talk about what they are certain they really did see—promising we too can see these objects if we look into the light shed by their examination. There is much security to be had there.

From gaze to vision: spaces for contemplation

In Turrell's viewing chambers, light does not reveal; "it is itself the revelation." Inhabiting them, we make what Jean-Miguel Garrigues called the "passage from the gaze to vision," not examining so much as admiring and wondering. This passage involves "quitting the sphere of the will in which modern man finds himself like a fish in water so as to enter into the ever so strange domain of [light], which demands of us the simple but so painful consent to the gift."¹⁴ In this domain, vision sees what gives itself—freely; vision does not grasp what it nevertheless sees. The viewing chambers thus become contemplative spaces where we give ourselves over to the mysterious non-objective presence of something we did not make, but that appears freely precisely when our activity has shut off or grown quiet.

That the vision we experience in Turrell's spaces is not foreign to contemplation can be seen in a brief consideration of several important characteristics of the contemplative tradition. My consideration here is guided by citations and conclusions found in the philosophers Emmanuel Martineau and Vincent Carraud, both of whom draw from the entry "contemplation" in the *Dictionnaire de Spiritualité*.¹⁵ Read in this context, Turrell's viewing chambers assist us in making a contemplative recovery as we take a step back *from* the self-assertive efforts of the modern subject and the clear and distinct world that comes to light thanks to these

efforts toward the light of contemplation, in which a different light arranges a different relation of human being to a different world.

The first way in which our experience in Turrell's spaces might be called contemplative is in its freedom. "Freedom is the mode of contemplation," Martineau notes. While freedom might suggest continuity between the modern, self-assertive human subject and the mode of contemplation, more specific consideration of contemplative freedom distinguishes them. Take the definition offered by the medieval doctor Jean Gerson: "Contemplation considers freely and with ease things that meditation searches for with care and great difficulty.... [It comes with] its own delight, which is likewise free and unencumbered [easy]." Contemplation is contrasted with "meditation, which is the gaze of a soul occupied in the search for truth and discovery of heavenly things,"¹⁶ in that contemplation is free from occupations, is not occupied, and does not have to discover anything at all in order to receive the vision it does. This is the simplicity of the contemplative vision and its delight.

This seemingly effortless or free seeing is often spoken of in terms of *vacatio* or *vacare*—a term that might be translated as *vacation* or *to take a vacation* so long as these phrases are detached from the modern sense of a temporary escape for the purpose of indulging in pleasures. Martineau cites the late 5th century priest Julianus Pomerius who wrote, "the contemplative life is nothing other than... release from [vacating?] all the occupations of the world [*vacatio ab omnibus occupationibus mundi*], or the study of divine letters, or... the vision of God itself."¹⁷ This release [*vacatio*] is not simply a negative movement away from (*ab*)..., but is equivalent to a positive movement of releasing oneself for..., in this case for a new vision, the vision of God. The release of contemplation is a freedom for receiving, not for making, constituting or discovering anything by the effort of meditation that shines a light on it. Such a freedom should be distinguished from that of the modern human subject whose freedom is a characteristic of the will, more specifically of a will free to act spontaneously, to determine itself from itself, and to master objects. The positive sense that *vacare* has in contemplation (release for) is nicely captured by the philosopher Ivan Illich, who translates Rufinus' *solus soli Dei vacans* as "in solitude makes himself free for God alone" and also renders Hugh of St. Victor's *sapientiae vacans* as "give themselves to wisdom." In the release of contemplation, one makes oneself vacant for.... In this way, vacating

frees (or releases) one, but it frees one to receive, not to exercise a will to mastery. In Illich's summary, "*Vacare* means 'to have been set or become free.' When Christian authors use the term the stress is not on [flight from habits], but on the freedom he takes of his own volition."¹⁸

Releasing us from what occupies us, contemplation offers a release to receive a vision that is not the product of a self-assertive, constitutive gaze. What does such a vision see? It sees *revelations* and, in Martineau's words, "all objects *revealed*." But seeing "all objects revealed" does not mean seeing some special objects. Rather, it means seeing all things now as revealed, given, rather than made, in a vision received. Even if contemplation is a release to *visio Dei*, such a vision is not of a particular thing or object, for God is seen in every object when all things are seen as revealed revelations. Martineau writes, "the object of contemplation is not a privileged object, but every object *in God and God in every object* as Robert Grosseteste put it: *in ipso omnia et in omnibus ipse*."¹⁹ Carraud concurs: "contemplation is contemplation of God, of God in all things and of all things in God.... *Contemplatio* is fundamentally contemplation of God... though it is perhaps never *intuitus solius Dei*."²⁰

This explanation of the contemplative *visio Dei* brings us back to its freedom, its *vacatio* or release. If contemplation were limited to a specific object, vision would be occupied in the effort of "seeking in all sorts of corners for the Beloved of its love or the love of its Beloved," as Francis de Sales put it. But, "everything can be the object of contemplation," Francis continues, when it appears in a vision that is directed to nothing in particular but is specified by having been received rather than sought out.²¹ Contemplation is not supposed to see anything in particular except all things as revealed in vision, leaving us no need to shine a light or bring something out of hiding from some dark corner.

Turrell's viewing chambers lead us into such a form of vision. They initiate us into a space where we are free to see and move about in the light, without our vision being asked to gaze at anything in particular. This is why it is so difficult to be sure you saw what you were supposed to see—in fact, you are not supposed to see anything in particular but all that presents itself in a vision given to you while you are still and quiet. The anxiety and disquiet of many of Turrell's critics arises, I believe, because of their own discomfort "making the passage" to this contemplative vision. They resist entering this ever so strange domain where they

are not responsible for bringing things to light but asked to contemplate the revelations of a light that is revealed to sight that sees with wonder and admiration.

The light of contemplation

The light seen in contemplative vision is described in the mystical theology of one of the most important theological sources for the contemplative tradition: the sixth century Syrian monk, Dionysius the Areopagite. As described by Dionysius, the light is greatly different from the use, metaphorical or physical, of light familiar to most moderns—either the inner light that eliminates doubt and makes for clear decisions, or the light of an examination that brings hidden things out of the threatening dark into the secure, but in both cases a light that reveals. In Dionysius' mystical contemplation, as for those who have been trained by Turrell's light-boxes, light has cosmological significance, not moral, personal, or inner significance (it pertains to reality and the structure of the real), and it is itself revelation. Though Turrell, raised a Quaker, has often cited as inspiration for his work his Quaker grandmother's injunction to "go inside and see the light," I can only feel that the light of which we become observant when we are initiated into his work is external, cosmic, or real—like the light that is creation and created things in the Dionysian contemplation of mystical theology.

According to Dionysius' contemplation, the created universe as a whole and in each of its parts is to be seen as a great revelation of divinity such that all things seen would make visible the mystery of the transcendent divine invisibility. This paradoxical revelation is described as a light (ray) that proceeds out or emanates from a light (source) so that all things seeing it might return to the transcendent divine light. Consider the opening passages of Dionysius' *Celestial Hierarchy*:

"Every good endowment and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights." Each procession of the Light spreads itself generously toward us, and in its power to unify, it stirs us by lifting us up. It returns us back to the oneness and deifying simplicity.... even though it works itself outward to multiplicity and proceeds outside of itself as befits its generosity, doing so to lift upward and to unify those beings for which it has a providential

responsibility; nevertheless, it remains inherently stable and it is forever one with its own unchanging identity.²²

Behind the complicated language is a fairly simple point. The cosmos as a whole, and in all its parts, is an overflow of divine light proceeding out of itself so that all things might return or be lifted up to divinity by being gathered into unity with the light as they enter into its light. Each and every thing in the created multiplicity is illuminated and at the same time illuminating, insofar as it both shines light and enlightens us so that we might see the light. In short, divinity is understood as the light that shines light, revealing itself thereby as light in the light it shines; the things of the cosmos are, in turn, understood as this light shined by the light—in other words, as the radiance, flow, or light that manifests the light.

But, importantly, the light remains hidden in its shining enlightenment, the divinity a mystery in its cosmic revelation. Dionysius continues the passage cited above by saying: “this divine ray can enlighten us only by being upliftingly concealed in a variety of sacred veils.”²³ Even as divinity shines or flows out of itself in the light that gathers all into unity with the divine Light, it remains in itself (“inherently stable ... forever one with its own unchanging identity”), since what it itself is is this radiating. And this implies its being “concealed”—or as he puts it in a famous letter to the monk Gaius, “[God’s] transcendent darkness remains hidden from all light,”²⁴ even amidst all the light shined by the divine light. Light, by definition or essentially, emits a ray or shines a light, and in this light shining it remains in itself, light.

This has important consequences for contemplation and what it means to see all things as revelation. Since light always remains in itself as it radiates or flows out for us, a mystery (the in-itself, remaining) remains hidden in the revelation (the for-us, proceeding out), a darkness keeps in itself at the heart of all the illumination poured out for contemplative vision. As Dionysius puts it, “the fire which warms and burns is never said itself to be burnt and warmed. Similarly it would be wrong to say... that light itself is enlightened.”²⁵ Observant of this darkness revealed in the things that come to light, contemplative vision will never have done with seeing as it looks at the things it sees. Seeing this light, its vision will never be able to equate its gaze with grasping or mastering the vision before it.

Aesthetics' contemplative recovery

The contemplative vision I have just described has important consequences that are not limited to just a theological significance but pertain also to aesthetic experience: the visible world is approached not objectively but in terms of beauty as thing for wonder and admiration. Inversely, one can imagine that aesthetic experience can nurture or train a certain contemplative vision that would connect in important ways with theological considerations, lending depth and mystery to a world that exceeds its flat objectivity. Something like the interlacing of the aesthetic and contemplative is staged in Turrell's viewing chambers.

Vision becomes contemplative not when it sees something solid or distinct in the clarity of light, but when it sees in and through distinct, visible objects the indistinct and invisible origin and end that shines darkly in them. In such a vision, the cosmos appears to the human being both as divine light to see (the universe is a theophany of light revealing God who is an invisible light) and light that must be unseen precisely because this light veils the dark light or "luminous darkness"²⁶ of the transcendently invisible divine light. The influential Catholic theologian Hans Urs von Balthasar connects this vision directly to an aesthetic significance when he puts it this way: "It is the greatness of man and his tragedy... to be immersed in the aesthetics of the world of images and at the same time to have irresistibly to dissolve all images in the light of the unimaginable."²⁷ When, as is the case for contemplative vision, light does not fall into oblivion in the space it clears or empties, but is instead an invisible visible or hidden presence, then the things we see "dissolve" (as von Balthasar puts it) in the light we see. We both see and do not see something. The aesthetic is both affirmed and denied—affirmed precisely in the name of that which denies it and denied precisely in view of that which affirms it. This could be compared favorably, I believe, to the experience of Turrell's work: "There is no image within [my work]," as Turrell says, yet this negation of the image seen is brought about precisely by the effect of that which lets us see all that we see; the image or object seen in Turrell's work is negated by the overwhelming light we see. Though the object is overwhelmed, how much the more do we see when we look into it—ininitely more as there is no end to sight as the back wall opens onto distance (for example, *Danae*).

The importance of this aesthetic to the recovery of contemplation and, inversely, the aesthetic importance of this contemplative recovery can be seen further by noting that, for von Balthasar, theological observance turns on the fact that the cosmos and the things we see in it are “the manifestation of the unmanifest,” a phrase with two inseparable senses. Understood as the “*manifestation* of the unmanifest,” it means the cosmos is a totality of beautiful things to see precisely insofar as it is the radiance of divine light. The light we see is a manifestation or “becoming visible in reality—not as *maya*, mere seeming illusion, but always as (real) manifestation of the unmanifest, of the ever greater and ever more hidden God.”²⁸ Just as Turrell rejects the claim that his lightboxes hold any illusion or *trompe l’oeil* but are real, since light itself is reality, so too does von Balthasar emphasize that the light manifest in the brilliant cosmos is also real, not an illusion to be banished when seen from the perspective of the absolute. In both the viewing chamber and the mystical cosmos, there is no point from which you can see such that appearances dissolve in unreality. In insisting on the reality of the images seen, contemplative vision is an affirmation of the aesthetic: it comes to rest on what it sees manifest in the revelation of divine light, just as we see the distinct shape as an obstacle before us in the spaces made by Turrell.

But there is a danger posed by the dazzling light of this total manifestation, according to Dionysius: namely, the risk of being held up by the objects seen in the light, the danger that one be occupied by the objects, and images one holds with a gaze that grasps what it sees. This gaze must be freed or liberated, vacated of all that occupies it in the manifestation of light if it is to continue on its aim at the divine. Settling in secure comfort with the objects it sees clearly and distinctly in oblivion of the light, it forgets the invisible and, coming to rest with the objects it holds, stops moving into the distance opened by the divine mystery.

The doorway becomes a wall, the window a façade (see, for example, a work such as *Ondoe Blue* or, though constructed differently, *Danae*).

This leads to the second sense, inseparable from the first, of von Balthasar’s twofold phrase. The beauty of the universe understood as a cosmic revelation of light is also a “manifestation of the *unmanifest*.” Von Balthasar explains: “Were the external splendor of the beautiful not the splendor of a mysterious depth... then it would not be the beautiful and would not awaken reverence before ‘the sacred mystery made manifest.’”

Our vision becomes observant of the beauty of the world, von Balthasar suggests, when it “is grounded in the worship of what is not manifest.”²⁹ Here, contemplative vision saves us from being stuck in the certain and secure, the objects that occupy us in our oblivion of the light in which we see them. It directs our vision through and beyond the images and objects we see to their unseen and invisible source or origin. This vision saves us from what occupies us by saving the invisible from oblivion, as if our fates were joined to that of the invisible.

The wall before us becomes an open door—admitting us into a “mysterious depth.” The façade that presents itself to vision becomes a window—giving onto the invisible, drawing us on to a vision without end.

If contemplative vision of the cosmic revelation of light does not neglect the invisible and yet remains a vision of the radiant splendor of beauty and beautiful things, it stands in a precarious relation to the aesthetic and to images, both affirming and transcending them, seeing both the solid and stable wall that presents itself and the doorway inviting us beyond all. Things grow deep and deeper when seen in a contemplative vision that sees the light rather than objects in the light. The name von Balthasar gives to this contemplative look into things is *wondering admiration*: “The more deeply our wondering admiration experiences the unmanifest God, and does not simply know him... the more the aesthetic relation is transcended.” But this transcendence of the aesthetic does not leave it behind, von Balthasar continues: “the more the aesthetic relation is transcended, ... the more the truth of the aesthetic emerges.”³⁰ Wondering admiration is this contemplative movement into the distance, as the universe grows darker the more light it becomes and lighter as we move into the darkness. Our admiration of the things we see grows deeper the more we see because the more we see of things when we are observant, the more the invisible grows. The more deeply we “look into” the wall, the more deeply we go through the doorway; once in the light, there is no end in sight as the back wall has been overwhelmed in the unlimited distance it opens and reveals to us.

Notes

1. This essay resituates small portions of chapter 3 from my previously published book *Arts of Wonder: Enchanting Secularity* – Walter De Maria, Diller + Scofidio, James Turrell, Andy Goldsworthy

© 2013 by The University of Chicago Press. All rights reserved. Readers will find in that book illustrations of the work described in this essay.

2. Turrell, James, in *Occluded Front*, Brown, Julia, ed. (The Lapis Press, 1985), p. 43.
3. Serres, Michel, *Hermès I. La communication* (Paris: ed. de Minuit, 1972), p. 43.
4. Blumenberg, Hans Blumenberg, "Light as Metaphor for Truth" in *Modernity and the Hegemony of Vision*. Levin, David, ed. (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1993), p. 53.
5. *Ibid.*, 34.
6. *Ibid.*, 52.
7. *Ibid.*, 32.
8. Blumenberg, Hans, *The Legitimacy of the Modern Age* (Cambridge, MA: M.I.T. Press, 1983), p. 200.
9. *Ibid.*, p. 173.
10. Didi-Huberman, Georges, *L'homme qui marchait dans la couleur* (Paris: ed. de Minuit, 2001).
11. *Ibid.*, 31.
12. *Ibid.*, 34, 32.
13. *Ibid.*, 35.
14. Garrigues, Jean-Miguel, O.P "Voir les cieux ouverts," in *La Vie Spirituelle* (Juillet-août 1973), p. 527.
15. Martineau, Emmanuel, *Malévitch et la philosophie* (Paris: L'âge d'homme, 1977); Vincent Carraud, *Pascal et la philosophie* (Paris: P. U. F., 1992); « Contemplation » in *Dictionnaire de Spiritualité* (t. II, col. 1643ff).
16. Martineau, 127, 128 [citing Jean Gerson, *L'oeuvre magistrale*, ed. Glorieux, P. (Desclée de Brouwer, 1962), pp. 273, 272]
17. *Ibid.*, 131 [citing *Dict. de spir.*, t. II, col. 1930].
18. Illich, Ivan, *In the Vineyard of the Text* (The University of Chicago Press, 1996), p. 61, 62, 62.
19. Martineau, 28, 133.
20. Carraud, 405, 406.
21. Martineau, 131, 132.
22. "The Celestial Hierarchy," in *Pseudo-Dionysius. The Complete Works* (New York: Paulist Press, 1987), p. 145-46 (120B-121B).
23. *Ibid.*, 146 (121B).
24. Letter 1 in *Ibid.*, 263 (1065A),
25. "The Divine Names" in *Ibid.*, 64 (645D).
26. "Mystical Theology" in *Ibid.*, 135 (997B).
27. Von Balthasar, Hans Urs, "Denys" in *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics*, vol. 3 (San Francisco: Crossroad, 1984), 179.
28. *Ibid.*, 164.
29. *Ibid.*, 164.
30. *Ibid.*, 165.